

Apple also allows users to review devices signed in to an Apple Account and remove devices they do not recognise.

Do not merely clear histories. Ask what each record reveals. A location timeline can show routines. Search history can reveal interests and concerns. Voice history may contain accidental recordings. Media histories can expose political, medical or religious interests. Connected-device lists can reveal a forgotten phone, shared computer or unauthorised session.

Step 6: Review applications, permissions and connections

An account may be secure while still sharing information with dozens of external applications. Review services connected through “Sign in with Google”, “Sign in with Facebook”, Microsoft, Apple or other identity providers. Remove applications you no longer use and examine the permissions of those you retain.

Google’s linked-app controls show where a user has signed in with Google, allowed access to Google Account data or linked another account. Meta similarly provides controls for applications, websites and games connected to Facebook. Removing a connection may stop future access, but it does not guarantee that information already copied by the third party is erased. Contact the external service when deletion is necessary.

On your phone, work through permission categories rather than opening applications randomly. Review location, contacts, photographs, microphone, camera, nearby devices, notifications and background activity. Ask whether each permission is essential, occasional or unnecessary. “Allow only while using” is often more proportionate than permanent access when the operating system offers that option.

Browser extensions deserve equal attention. An extension that can “read and change all your data on websites you visit” may observe far more than its small toolbar icon suggests. Remove abandoned extensions and prefer the minimum number necessary.

Build the Personal Exposure Spreadsheet

Create these columns:

Identifier | Service or page | Information exposed | Public or account-only | Who controls it | Evidence saved | Risk level | Required action | Deadline | Status

Use three risk levels. Mark an item high when it exposes a home address, live location, identity document, financial information, account access, family safety issue or credible impersonation. Mark it medium when it links identities, reveals routines or exposes unnecessary contact details. Mark it low when the information is harmless, outdated or intentionally public.

Then assign one action:

- **Keep:** Public information that serves a clear purpose.
- **Minimise:** Remove unnecessary fields, permissions or history.

CHECK BREACH EXPOSURE

A breach result does not prove that someone currently controls your account. It means information associated with an identifier appeared in a known incident and should be treated according to what was exposed.

Mozilla Monitor uses the Have I Been Pwned database to check known breaches and alert users when monitored accounts appear in a leak. Its guidance recommends responding according to the breached data, including changing compromised passwords and strengthening affected accounts.

Follow this sequence:

1. Check every current and old email address.
2. Record the breached service and approximate date.
3. Note the exposed data categories.
4. Change any password that was used there.
5. Change the same or similar password everywhere else.
6. Enable multi-factor authentication where available.
7. Review recovery addresses, phone numbers and active sessions.
8. Watch for targeted phishing using the leaked information.

Never paste a current password into an unfamiliar “breach checker”. A legitimate exposure check usually requires an email address, username or safely handled password hash – not your live credentials.

- **Separate:** Move the activity to another email, browser profile or identity.
- **Secure:** Change credentials, sessions or recovery methods.
- **Request removal:** Contact the website, search engine or account owner.
- **Archive and delete:** Save what is needed, then close the account.

Work from high risk downward. Fixing one primary email account may protect twenty connected services, while deleting ten harmless forum comments may change little. Recheck the audit every three to six months and after major life events, device losses or breach notifications.

A successful audit does not produce an empty search page. It produces awareness. You know which identities exist, where they overlap, what organisations retain and what strangers can infer. That knowledge turns privacy from a vague intention into a manageable set of decisions. 